1.2 The Struggle for New York

One of the worst things you can do is underestimate an opponent. The Americans looked like a ragtag bunch, but they had advantages the more disciplined British failed to see, and this oversight cost them.

MAIN IDEA Due to poor planning, the British expectation that they would dominate the Hudson River Valley proved to be incorrect.

HUDSON RIVER VALLEY

Even though Washington's troops were victorious in New Jersey, the British still controlled New York City. From there, they planned to capture the Hudson River Valley. They hoped to divide New England from the rest of the states and bring a swift conclusion to the colonial rebellion.

General Howe, a lieutenant general of British forces in North America, planned to seize the Hudson River Valley using three armies. In 1777, he sent a regiment under the command of British general **John Burgoyne** from Boston to Canada. Burgoyne's troops were to move by boat down Lake Champlain. Howe's own troops would move north to meet them. Another force, led by British lieutenant colonel Barry St. Leger, would move east from western New York along the Mohawk River to link up with the other two armies in Albany, New York.



On their way south from Lake Champlain, Burgoyne's troops took Fort Ticonderoga, but they quickly ran into problems. Burgoyne had overloaded his troops with baggage, including cartloads of his own clothing. American forces chopped down trees and rolled boulders into the path of the British troops, making a march of 23 miles take 24 days. Then, near Saratoga, New York, the Americans surrounded Burgoyne's troops. When Burgoyne called for **reinforcements**, or more soldiers and supplies, from New York, he found that Howe had changed his plans. Instead of joining Burgoyne's troops, Howe had decided to head for Philadelphia. His route there was roundabout. He sailed around Delaware and up Chesapeake Bay to Pennsylvania. Washington tried and failed to block Howe's advance through Pennsylvania. The British

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A Mohawk Loyalist

Joseph Brant was born by the Ohio River and educated at an Indian charity school in Connecticut. His sister married a British Army officer, whom Brant followed into battle during the French and Indian War. His loyalties remained with the British throughout the American Revolution, and he skillfully led Iroquois Loyalist troops in battle throughout the Mohawk Valley. After the war, he worked for peace on the frontier. For his service, the British awarded him land in Canada, where he and his followers eventually settled.



A gorget was worn by officers to protect their throats during battle. King George gave this gorget to Brant as a gift.

occupied and successfully defended Philadelphia and nearby Germantown against another attack by Washington's troops in October 1777.

ALONG THE MOHAWK RIVER

Meanwhile, St. Leger continued to push toward Albany. After crossing Lake Ontario, he led his army along the Mohawk River. And he was not alone. Iroquois warriors from the region supported St. Leger's troops.

The Six Nations of the Iroquois had formed their alliance around 1720. They signed a treaty with Britain in 1768 to establish a boundary between Native American and European lands. Then, in 1775, as the American Revolution approached, the Six Nations agreed to remain neutral. However, after war broke out, both the Americans and the British pressured the nations in the alliance to choose sides. Eventually the Six Nations decided to split their loyalties. The Mohawk sided with the British.

Mohawk chief **Joseph Brant** commanded his troops as they fought alongside St. Leger in the Mohawk River Valley. But they encountered American resistance at Fort Stanwix in 1777. When they heard that officer Benedict Arnold was approaching from the east with more American troops—and Native American allies—St. Leger and his Iroquois allies retreated. Their flight and Howe's change of plans meant that no one would be coming to help Burgoyne once he got to Albany.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What errors did Burgoyne make as he headed to the Hudson River Valley?
2. **INTERPRET MAPS** Along what river did most of the American victories occur in 1777?
3. **FORM AND SUPPORT OPINIONS** Do you think Burgoyne and Howe were ready for battle in America? Why or why not?

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